

GT SPOTLIGHT

Why Flock Safety Finds Itself in a Surveillance Backlash

Flock Safety and its automated license plate reader tools have many supporters. But a growing backlash against the company around

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Flock Safety

Flock Safety's automatic license plate readers have helped police [catch violent criminals and thieves](#), locate stolen cars, find missing

The surveillance technology has also, however, sparked a backlash among residents, civil liberty advocates and politicians who consi

That backlash has led to new state laws designed to protect citizens against alleged abuses of Flock's automatic license plate readers

It has also put the company on the defensive and raised questions about the future of public safety technology, which is embracing AI. Such improvements might be cheered by law enforcement. But they leave many critics distrustful and ready to lobby elected officials. Flock has become the “poster boy” for growing worries about potential invasions of privacy via cutting-edge police technology, says R

“What Americans are starting to realize is there’s been an entire surveillance industry erected around them,” Frommer says.

FLOCK’S GROWTH

In some ways, Flock is a government technology success story.

Founded in 2017, Atlanta-based Flock Safety’s backers include investment and political heavyweight Andreessen Horowitz, along with. Flock’s total funding stands at \$1.2 billion, [according to Crunchbase](#), including a recent [\\$275 million investment round](#). That round valued the company at \$1.2 billion. The company says it has more than [12,000 clients across the U.S.](#), which includes more than 5,000 law enforcement agencies, 1,000 cities, and 100 state and local governments. Flock has also moved into [drones](#), another [growing area](#) for public safety tech.

Yet a backlash against the company has mounted, and for now that backlash focuses on its most famous offering, ALPRs. They use plate recognition to identify vehicles. Well-publicized accusations of misuse of that tech — including for recent federal immigration raids, which are [increasingly unpopular](#) — have led to a loss of business. Between August 2021 and May 2026, 82 Flock contracts were terminated in 28 states, according to reporting by the [San Francisco Chronicle](#). An anti-Flock online operation called DeFlock estimates that 68 cities specifically have rejected the company’s tech since August 2021. Flock, and some of its largest investors, did not provide comment for this story.

But through blog posts and previous comments to *Government Technology*, Flock has insisted that its employees follow the law and do not share data with federal immigration authorities. In reference to concerns that critics have raised over the company sharing data with federal immigration authorities, Flock has denied such claims. Flock has touted its development of [auditing and monitoring tools](#) and [policies](#) designed to protect against clients and others who would misuse the data.

THE BACKLASH

Much of the backlash to Flock’s technology comes from concerns about privacy.

In modern life, many common products and services transfer tremendous amounts of personal data to faceless third parties, including insurance companies, employers, and social media. “As surveillance grows, privacy protections are not keeping pace,” said M. Lorena González, legislative director for the ACLU of Washington. Such distrust is reflected in a [new Washington state law](#) which limits use of Flock readers and their data to felony investigations and other serious crimes. More anti-Flock laws loom, including a [proposed federal bill](#) that would keep federal highway funding from any state that allows ALPRs.

Flock also attracts ire from citizens.

Jason Hunyar lives in Dunwoody, Ga., an Atlanta suburb, and he said he began opposing the technology after Flock [used data](#) from it. Hunyar told *Government Technology* he made more than 100 Freedom of Information Act (FOIA) requests about Flock. He also [public](#). Hunyar isn't against all emerging police tech. He supports upgraded 911 call center platforms to speed up emergency response. But Flock. The Dunwoody City Council ended up unanimously approving a new agreement with Flock. [The agreement](#), however, prohibits Flock. Meanwhile, Will Freeman, who runs DeFlock, says there is a lack of independent studies that confirm the crime-fighting successes claimed by Flock. "These are very dangerous tools," Freeman says. "And the problem is bigger than Flock. We move very quickly into adopting tech before we have the data to prove it works."

PROCUREMENT PRACTICES

Part of that speed perhaps comes from mastery of gov tech procurement, which critics and supporters agree it does well enough to star Agencies such as the [Cook County Sheriff's Office in Illinois](#) — home of Chicago — have a [cooperative, or piggyback, contract](#) with Flock. Such contracts are mainstream in gov tech. Also in Cook County, money to pay for Flock has come out of the Sheriff's Office's operating budget. That funding has [sparked controversy](#), however, as the Sheriff's Office, which already has 125 Flock ALPRs, seeks more money for the technology.

DANE COUNTY, WIS.

One area that reflects the ongoing debate over Flock is Dane County, Wis., which includes Madison, a city that is home to both the state and federal governments. County supervisors in April voted 32-1 to stop the sheriff's office from spending \$80,000 on Flock ALPRs; the office had received 24 cameras. The sheriff's office tells *Government Technology* the cameras assisted in 18 arrests, the recovery of 12 stolen vehicles and three homes. But concerns about privacy and data sharing sank the new deal, with [county officials criticizing](#) sharing ALPR data with federal agencies. "Nothing about this action suggests that our deputies have misused this system," said Supervisor Chad Kemp in a [statement](#). "But the county is not going to fund it." By June, county officials [moved to reinstate](#) that \$80,000 in ALPR funding, though that money would probably go to a Flock competitor. And the renewed spending comes with conditions: Data must remain under the "full control" of the sheriff's office and "transparent documentation." Dane County Sheriff's Office Capt. Ira Simpson tells *Government Technology* that ALPR tech is important, but acknowledged that the technology has its drawbacks. "Our focus is not on revisiting Flock specifically," Simpson says, but "identifying" other suppliers that can both meet the crime-fighting needs and address the concerns.

MORE ACCOUNTABILITY

Similar concerns about sharing data with feds led to the removal of 16 Flock cameras in Cambridge, Mass., last year — a decision affirmed by the state Supreme Court. The city plans to evaluate other ALPR tech, but with a more skeptical view.

The Chicago suburb of Oak Park offers a similar lesson: Officials and residents aren't swearing off ALPRs as they kick Flock to the curb. [Village Trustee Derek Eder](#) voted "no." And he now says he has a "high bar" for any new deal for surveillance technology. He favors a more robust oversight process.

Supporters of Flock — reportedly in contention for an FBI contract to [access ALPR data](#) — are fighting back, sometimes in dramatic ways.

For instance, after Bandera, a small town in Texas, voted in May to fire Flock, a councilmember threatened to introduce a bill [banning](#) the company.

Around the same time, Rahul Sidhu, Flock's chief strategy officer, posted a [hard-worded message on his LinkedIn](#) in response to Austin Mayor Steve Adler's criticism.

He described how suspects in stolen vehicles conducted a shooting spree in Austin but were only caught in nearby Manor, Texas, where they were shot.

"After the suspects drove into Manor to continue their shooting spree, Manor PD located them almost immediately. The residents of Manor are grateful for the police's quick response."

But Frommer, the attorney who has filed suits against them, argues that Flock can only blame itself and its style of fast growth for its problems.

"The lack of guardrails are what hurt the company," Frommer says. "We are not trying to ban those cameras. We are just saying go through the proper channels."

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